MacZine
THE MACTECH SOLUTIONS NEWSLETTER
ISSUE N° 002 · JULY 2026 · MACTECHSOLUTIONSLLC.COM/MACZINE

CMMC

The First 90 Days of a CMMC Level 2 Program

A practitioner's sequence for the first 90 days of CMMC Level 2: scope the CUI boundary, baseline against NIST 800-171, and start evidence discipline early.

BY **MACTECH SOLUTIONS** READING TIME · 3 MIN CMMC · NIST-800-171 · CUI

Most CMMC Level 2 programs don't fail at assessment - they fail in the first quarter, when the scoping decisions and documentation habits that determine everything downstream get made by default instead of on purpose. Here is the sequence we run with new clients, and why the order matters.

FIELD COPY
ISSUE N° 002
CMMC

Days 0–30: Scope before you spend

The single most expensive mistake in CMMC preparation is buying controls for systems that never needed to be in scope.

Find the CUI first. Not "where could CUI be" - where it actually is. Pull your active DoD contracts and look for the DFARS 252.204-7012 clause and CUI markings in the deliverable flow. Trace how that data enters your environment, who touches it, and where it rests. Every system in that path is in scope; everything else is a candidate for isolation.

Shrink the boundary aggressively. A CUI enclave - a segmented environment where CUI lives and the rest of your business doesn't - is almost always cheaper than certifying your whole network. Ten workstations in an enclave beats two hundred in scope. This decision has to come first because it changes the denominator on every control that follows.

Name an owner. Not a committee. One person with the authority to make scoping calls and the calendar time to run the program. CMMC efforts without a single accountable owner reliably stall at the self-assessment stage.

3 min

READING TIME, NO PAYWALL, NO POP-UPS

◆ ABOUT MACZINE

Written, reviewed and versioned in the open — published from Git, reviewed like code.

Days 30–60: Baseline honestly

With a boundary drawn, assess the enclave against all 110 NIST SP 800-171 requirements. Two rules make this useful instead of theater:

1. **Score it like an assessor would.** "We mostly do this" is NOT MET. The DoD assessment methodology is binary per objective - partial credit only exists in your POA&M, not your score.
2. **Write the finding down even when it hurts.** Your SPRS score is a legal representation of this baseline. An honest 88 with a credible POA&M is defensible; an optimistic 110 is a False Claims Act exposure.

The output of this phase is three documents that will live for the rest of the program: a System Security Plan skeleton describing the boundary and each control's implementation status, a POA&M listing every gap with an owner and a date, and your initial SPRS submission.

Days 60–90: Build evidence discipline, not binders

The habit that separates programs that pass from programs that panic is started here: **evidence is captured when the work happens, not reconstructed before the assessment.**

- Screenshots, configs, and log samples go into an organized evidence store, named by control, dated, as changes are made
- Recurring controls (access reviews, training, scans) get calendar entries with the evidence artifact as the meeting's required output

- The SSP gets updated in the same change window as the system - a document-as-you-build rule, borrowed from RMF practice, that is dramatically cheaper than document-after-the-fact

By day 90 you are not assessment-ready - nobody is in one quarter. What you have is a scoped boundary that caps your cost, an honest score that caps your legal exposure, and an evidence pipeline that compounds instead of a binder that rots.

Where programs actually stall

Three patterns we see repeatedly: scoping revisited every month because leadership never signed off on the enclave decision; the POA&M treated as a wish list with no dates or owners; and evidence collection deferred until an assessment date forces a six-month archaeology project. All three are quarter-one failures wearing quarter-four costumes.

MacTech Solutions runs CMMC readiness assessments and builds CUI enclave architectures for DoD primes and subcontractors. If you're starting your 90 days, talk to us before you buy anything. ◆
